ALLEGHENY MILLWORK

TOOLBOX TALK — WEEKLY SAFETY MEETING

Millwork | Carpentry | Interior Finishes | Material Handling

WEEK 07

Date: ______________________ **Supervisor:** ______________________

Project / Job Name: ______________________

TOPIC: Circular Saw Safety & Blade Binding Prevention

OVERVIEW:

The circular saw is portable, powerful, and present on virtually every millwork and finish carpentry job. It is also involved in thousands of serious injuries annually. Most circular saw injuries involve kickback — caused by the blade binding in the cut — or contact with the blade during material

TALKING POINTS — Read to Crew:

1. Blade binding is the root cause of most circular saw kickbacks. Binding happens when the kerf closes on the blade, usually because the workpiece is not properly supported and sags or shifts during the cut. Always support both sides of a cut so the kerf opens rather than closes as the cut progresses. When cutting sheet goods across sawhorses, make sure both sides of the sheet are
2. Blade depth is a safety setting, not just a convenience setting. Set the blade to extend no more than 1/4 inch below the bottom of the material you are cutting. A deeper blade exposure increases the chance of contact if the saw kicks back or if the blade contacts something unexpected. It also increases the severity of a cut if contact does occur. Check blade depth every time you switch
3. The blade guard on your circular saw is a spring-loaded safety device. It retracts as the blade enters the cut and returns to cover the blade when the cut is complete. Never pin back the blade guard, never remove it, and never use a saw with a damaged guard that does not return properly. If the guard sticks or does not retract smoothly, have the saw serviced before using it again.
4. Always use a straightedge or guide fence for long rip cuts. Freehand rip cuts are inaccurate and dangerous — if the blade wanders off-line, the operator instinctively tries to steer it back, which can cause binding and kickback. A straightedge clamped to the workpiece takes 30 seconds to set up and gives you a safe, accurate cut every time.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS — Ask Your Crew:

Q1: What is the correct blade depth setting, and how do you check it before cutting?

Q2: What do you do if your circular saw guard does not retract or return properly?

KEY SAFETY POINTS:

- Set blade depth to just clear the material — no more than 1/4 inch below
- Support both sides of cuts in sheet goods to prevent binding
- Always retract the guard or unplug before changing any blade
- Never remove guards — they exist to protect you
- Use a straightedge or guide for all long rip cuts

Crew sign-in sheet on page 2 — all 30 crew members sign on the following page.

CREW SIGN-IN SHEET

WEEK 07

By signing, I confirm I attended this toolbox talk and understand the topic discussed.

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